Having discussed various issues with the national leaders, field commanders and my advisers at the Army HQ, I held my first conference in February 2005. This was to spell out the road map of the next three years to my principal staff officers, the heads of arms and services, and other senior officers of the Army HQ, and enunciate my aim, concepts, principles and key result areas (KRAs). A few months later, I reiterated these core policies and key objectives during the army commanders' conference in April 2005, where we discussed ways to improve the state of the army and achieve our aim. Excerpts of my concepts disseminated to the media and in the public domain are reproduced below:

Readiness to carry out our operational mission shall be one of our primary KRAs. To quote Chanakya, 'If a society seeks to live in peace, it should be prepared for war, and a unilateral desire for peace cannot ensure peace.' We are well aware of the live challenge of a proxy war that we are facing in Jammu and Kashmir and insurgency or terrorism that occupies our attention in the northeast. Besides, we have unresolved boundary issues with Pakistan and China. Consequently, there is a requirement to deploy the army and paramilitary forces to guard these frontiers. The strife and tension that has engulfed most countries in our region needs to be kept in mind. We must constantly review and refine our doctrine, operational and logistics plans and ensure the desired level of equipment fitness.

We should ensure that we win the war against terror – the proxy war unleashed by Pakistan in Jammu and Kashmir, the insurgency in Nagaland and the actions of outfits like ULFA in Assam and Manipur. Our aim should be to carry out successful operations in J&K and the northeast and bring down the level of violence so that the civil administration, paramilitary forces and the police are able to function in an appropriate manner and provide good governance.

There can be no substitute for realistic and operational-oriented training. We must train for the modern hi-tech battlefield and the future war, not the last one. The side which is adept at netcentric and information warfare and has the required night-fighting capability shall carry the day in any future conflict. The war doctrine should be incorporated in our exercises and practised at the tactical, operational and strategic levels.

We must provide top class leadership to our soldiers, who are amongst the finest in the world. To quote Field Marshal Slim, 'The real test of leadership is not if your men will